



I HAVE NEVER STAYED SO LONG ANYWHERE

LAST YEAR AT MARIENBAD / 1961

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Experimental

DIRECTOR

Alain Resnais

WRITER

Alain Robbe-Grillet

STARS

Delphine Seyrig, Giorgio Albertazzi, Sacha Pitoëff

BEFORE

1955 *Night and Fog* is Resnais' contemplation of the memory of the Nazi concentration camps.

1959 *Hiroshima mon amour*, Resnais' first big success, deals with memory and forgetfulness in the wake of the Hiroshima bomb.

AFTER

1977 *Providence*, Resnais' movie about the memories of an aging writer, is hailed in France as a masterpiece but panned by critics in the US.

Beautifully shot in black and white and in widescreen, Alan Resnais' *Last Year at Marienbad* has a glacier-paced coolness. Lacking any conventional narrative, it deliberately challenges preconceptions about how movies should work. This approach has influenced a generation of directors, including Stanley Kubrick, David Lynch, and Peter Greenaway.

The movie is set in a palatial hotel in rural central Europe. Here, a handsome stranger known only as X (Giorgio Albertazzi) insists to a beautiful fellow guest, known as A (Delphine Seyrig), that they met and fell in love the previous year in the resort of Marienbad, where she

agreed to leave her husband M (Sacha Pitoëff) the following year. A denies his claims, but X persists, in between playing rounds of the mathematical game Nim with M, which M always wins.

For Resnais, the movie was an exploration of time and memory. The script, written by experimental novelist Alain Robbe-Grillet, fuses past and present in a series of surreal, almost nightmarishly repetitive tableaux. Resnais turns these scenes into a dreamlike world in which all is reduced to appearances and games of mirrors. Life goes on in a seemingly ritualistic way, full of allusions and symbols that leave the viewer continually



Alain Resnais Director

Born in Vannes in Brittany in 1922, French filmmaker Alain Resnais

continues to divide critics. Later in life he focused more on farce and comedy, but in the first half of his career he worked with leading modern writers such as Alain Robbe-Grillet and Marguerite Duras to create

enigmatic and poetic movies about time and memory, which some celebrate as masterpieces and others find pretentious. Resnais died in 2014.

Key movies

1959 *Hiroshima mon amour*
1961 *Last Year at Marienbad*
1977 *Providence*